

NOTHING SEPARATED THE MUZZLE from his temple except for a bit of that trademark white *safa* around his head, tied the same way his *tangawallah* father perhaps used to in the blazing-hot summers of Allahabad back in the day. A gun coming out of nowhere, a flash of burning light, a staccato burst and the burly Atiq Ahmed, Uttar Pradesh's dreaded mafia don, and his brother Ashraf, slumped to the ground. With them crumbled an empire of crime that had long metastasised to other parts of the body politic—including a term in the Lok Sabha, and several in the Uttar Pradesh assembly. A ganglord-politician's murder on live TV was dramatic enough to find space in the world press, and perhaps an unwanted deviation from the narrative being crafted by Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath. But even if by unintended association, that infamous freeze-frame has become a moment that encapsulates an epic battle of the law—in all its shades of black, white and grey—against the entrenched network of mafiosi that has choked the state's political economy for decades. It's a battle that has cleared parts of a lawless jungle while also leaving a cloud of questions in its place and pushed at the edges of the definition of justice while scripting a new chapter for it.